

CAD FORUM

GUEST FORUM ON RHETORICAL GENRE

Kevin Douglas Kuswa, *University of Richmond*

There are countless ways to think about rhetorical genre and the taxonomic impulses of style. Playing with field, area, topic, sentiment or even ideology, rhetorical genre is a series of ways to classify links between discourse and/as materiality. This issue is built on the notion of rhetorical genre as “discursive assemblage” in a broad sense and, from Harrell and Linkugel (1978), classifications of rhetorical situation in public discourse in a narrow sense. The genesis traces to a panel at the Seattle RSA on deliberative and judicial rhetoric in the regulation of public controversy. As this forum moors itself in some of the traditional quandaries surrounding genre, the articles that make up the compilation follow wildly divergent trajectories on the notions of rhetoric style and constitution, creating a festival of academic inquiry difficult to look past and satisfying to embrace.

We start with an invitation from Brent Saindon, accepted through the course of the forum, to permute the works of Michael Calvin McGee (1980, 1990) into a masterful synthesis of critical theory, the “ideographic fragment.” This notion allows a rhetorical critic to evaluate a significant trope, such as equality, and assess its

contextual moment. Through Saindon's intervention we see how, for example, Singer's application of equality to animal liberation operates inside, outside, and between a given rhetor's intent. The discourse of equality as applied to animals is an ideographic fragment because it retrenches ideologies on both sides, it enables discourse formations to shift from one context to another, and it defies (while constituting) the stable speaker or author. As Saindon carefully notes, we should criticize how these processes "are the products of a dispersed, multiplicitous public sphere containing a cacophony of vernacular voices."

The call for further research into this nuanced form of criticism emerges in the forum's subsequent essays, moving through an outline of the genre of public diplomacy, the application of such criticism to the links between war and nationalism in a crucial address by President of the Confederacy Jefferson Davis, the refusal to accept argumentative logics justifying slavery or restrictions on reproductive freedom, and the "writing out" of transgressive identity discourse seen through a suicide girl's tattoos. Matt Gerber adds the next step to the collection with a sharp description of "public diplomacy" as a rich area of research in communication studies, but also a genre that incorporates the ways discourse in international relations can include a give-and-take or partially open-ended dialogue. Theorizing the concept of "listening" in international relations by emphasizing limited dialogue and synthesis brilliantly highlights and adds to the utility of public diplomacy as a field of study, what Gerber calls "the ongoing discursive management of national reputation."

And, where else would such a field emerge but in the speeches of Presidents in American history making appeals to go to war? Jarrod Atchison joins the conversation with a wonderful piece of historical criticism that defends and expands the notion of "war rhetoric" as argumentation designed to justify or maintain the legitimacy of taking a nation to war. When Jefferson Davis made the choice to downplay adherence to slavery and states' rights in order to conscript slaves into a beleaguered army, he found himself caught between the pragmatic need to find additional soldiers and

the larger demands of a nation's identity. Even though Davis's challenge to slavery was only temporary, his inability to imagine an alternative community for the Confederacy signaled the eventual defeat of that nation.

The article written by myself and co-authors Paul Achter and Liz Lauzon also grapples with the discourse and public controversy of slavery, tracing how the same arguments isolated by Atchison during the reign of the Confederacy have crossed time and context to re-appear in debates over abortion and reproductive freedom. In other words, arguments that once were used to justify slavery, not from a national unity or economic perspective, but from a individual sense of "doing what is right for the slaves," now appear as conservative attempts to prohibit the choice to have an abortion by deploying the argument that the interests of the fetus must be protected at all costs. Yes, the genre of "body arguments" is now grounded in multiple locations in communication studies, but it may also fill in a missing component alluded to throughout this forum.

Rhetorical genre always flows discursively through argumentation, for the interests and arrangements affected by a realm will argue with and against that realm, just as boundaries themselves represent and manifest argumentation. The bodies of animals in the context of equality and animal rights, the bodies of the negotiators and their states during a period of public diplomacy, the bodies of the soldiers and the slaves pitted against the body of the nation during the Civil War, and the bodies of the women literally subordinated to images of the mythical fetus—what Berlant calls infantile citizenship—all work to carry an embodied notion of discourse beyond the limitations of a particular genre. It is fitting, then, to conclude with the text as body and the body as text in Megan Harlow's compelling account of Jaylin. Jaylin self-identifies as a suicide girl and expresses herself through a series of tattoos, yet, as most Suicide Girls, she "embraces her 'social death' and erotic potential through tattoos and alternative sexual performances...rejecting a vision of beauty that would airbrush away her desire." The desires are often contradictory, but

always vivid and lived through the skin as the phrase “art as life” takes on new and more permanent contours.

Eclectic and complementary, the pieces in this forum ask a number of important questions for the study of rhetoric and beyond. When we detect patterns and common forms, when we encounter situations with previous parallels, how can we merge those overlapping elements while still carving out enough space for the fidelity of the event itself—the specifics and why they matter? Genre tells us that we should and must wallow in the specifics and acknowledge our own presence there, for doing so ensures that we will not stray far from the goal of energizing and relevant scholarship. All of this “mattering,” frankly, is the means by which we describe and criticize at the same time, admitting to our standpoint and adding layers to the inevitable tessellation that is the communication genre.

References

- Harrell, J., & Linkugel, W. A. (1978). On rhetorical genre: An organizing perspective. *Philosophy and Rhetoric*, 11, 262-279.

Kevin Kuswa is Director of Debate, Richmond University

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Cross Examination Debate Association and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.